

How Survey Framing and Partisan Identity Shape American Views on Race in Education

Data Report | Yibarek Tadesse

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1 Introduction

Due to their rapid development, children are very malleable, so it is no surprise that American classrooms have always been a battleground for politicized socialization, the way people try to influence how and what politics are taught to children. Culture wars over curriculum have existed for decades, but recent movements like Black Lives Matter (BLM) have reignited concerns over whether systemic inequality should be taught in schools at all. Public polling on these issues frequently highlights demographic divides, but it doesn't always capture the nuance underneath. General support for racial education remains in favor, but public sentiment is highly vulnerable to framing (**Figure 1**). Across three national surveys, this report finds that American opinion on race in education is driven less by policy details than by rhetorical framing, partisan identity, and the lessons about race that parents pass on at home, revealing that vibes can matter just as much as the substance of what is being proposed.

2 Methodology

Three national surveys provide the data for this report. The 2023 Cooperative Congressional Election Study (CCES23) featured two framing experiments in which respondents were randomly assigned to one of four equally weighted wording conditions (25% each) for VAN025 (general race education) and VAN026 (ethnic studies), both rated on a seven-point agreement scale (1 = strongly oppose, 7 = strongly support). Each condition varied across two axes: whether the curriculum was framed as mandatory or permissive, and how content was altered (historical vs. present-day racism for VAN025; minority-focused vs. multi-ethnic framing for VAN026). The VAND0049 dataset included anti-CRT law opposition on a four-point scale using partisan identity and other educational ideologies to take a deeper look. RPS Wave 1 data set was used to examine BLM support (Q26) alongside seven items regarding parent-child racial teachings (Q37 series). OLS regression was used across all three datasets, with non-response codes removed before analysis. All estimates are unweighted.

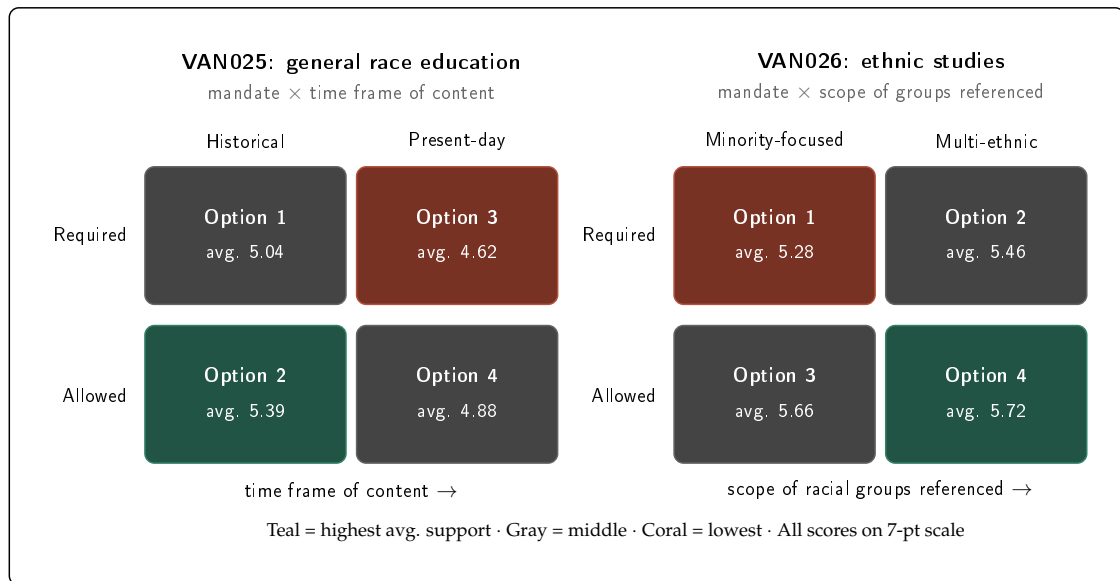


Figure 1: Visual breakdown of the CCES23 survey framing experiment designs.

3 Framing and Race Education (CCES23)

Changing the wording of a race education question did not move overall public opinion uniformly, but certain phrasings did act as triggers for specific groups (**Figure 2**). The "Allowed to learn about history" framing (Option 2), which combined an "Allowed" mandate with "Historical" content, generated the highest average support score of 5.39. The "Required to learn about present-day" framing (Option 3), which combined a "Required" mandate with "Present-day" content, produced the lowest score at 4.62. Two middle-ground framings, Option 1 (Required/Historical) and Option 4 (Allowed/Present-day), landed at 5.04 and 4.88 respectively. That 0.77-point drop in the overall average from Option 2 to Option 3 was not evenly distributed across the sample. It was driven by respondents who intend to vote for Donald Trump. As shown below (**Figure 2**), support dropped 1.73 points (from 4.57 to 2.84) when the framing shifted from Option 2 to Option 3. Meanwhile, the support among all other respondents remained nearly flat across all four conditions (hovering between 5.61 and 5.9). The shift to a "Required" and "Present-day" framing appeared to heavily activate partisan identity rather than shifting opinion uniformly. The ethnic studies question (VAN026), which tested the mandate against the scope of racial groups referenced (Minority-focused vs. Multi-ethnic), told a quieter story. Averages here ranged narrowly from a low of 5.28 (Required/Minority-focused) to a high of 5.72 (Allowed/Multi-ethnic) across the four framings, with "Allowed" and "Multi-ethnic" framing generating the highest average support.

How Survey Framing Activates Partisan Identity (VAN025)

Prospective Trump voters show a sharp drop in support when classrooms are forced to teach about present-day racism.

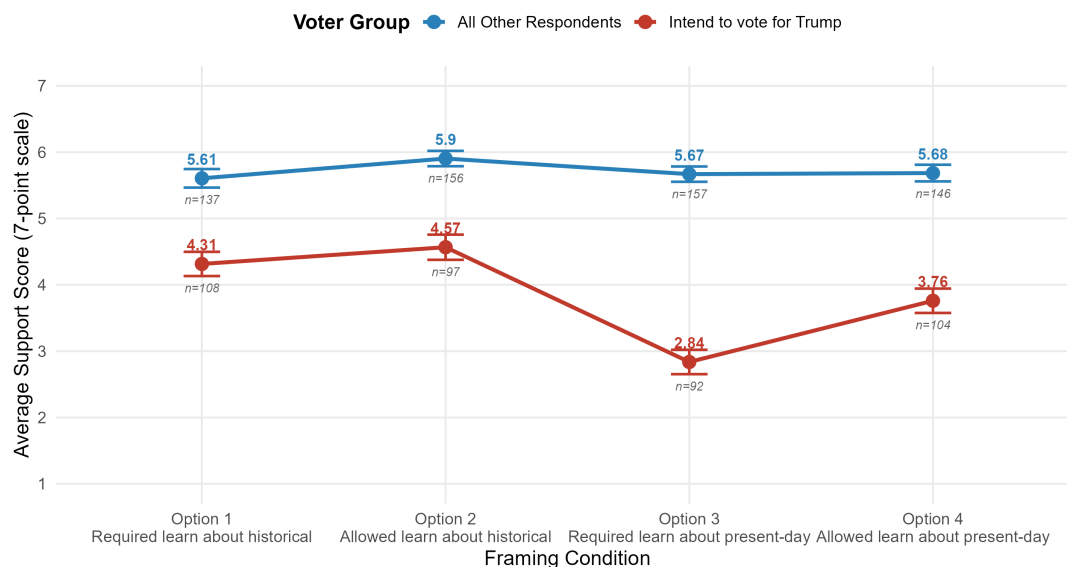


Figure 2: Average race education support scores (VAN025, 7-point scale) by framing condition and voter group. Source: CCES23.

4 Anti-CRT Legislation (VAND0049)

The VAND0049 sample leaned against restrictions on race-related content with 59.5% of people somewhat or strongly opposing laws banning CRT while 40.5% favored them. The most revealing finding here is what did not drive the divide. Gender, the one demographic in the model besides race, showed no statistically significant impact. What separated Pro-CRT and Anti-CRT people were their beliefs about what education is meant for. Respondents who believed schools have a responsibility to teach uncomfortable racial truths strongly opposed the restrictions ($p < 0.001$), as did those who placed personal importance on discussing race with children ($p < 0.001$). On the other side, respondents who believed that teaching racial history as a story of ongoing injustice undermines American founding ideals were the most consistent supporters of bans ($p < 0.001$), with Republican identity adding onto that effect at every step (**Figure 3**). These competing values suggest that the real disagreement is over which version of America's story public schools are allowed to tell, not the pedagogy itself. Racial minority groups showed higher baseline opposition to the laws compared to their white counterparts even after taking into account their ideology, which may suggest that minority groups were more likely to oppose Anti-CRT legislation due to a feeling of their own history being in jeopardy.

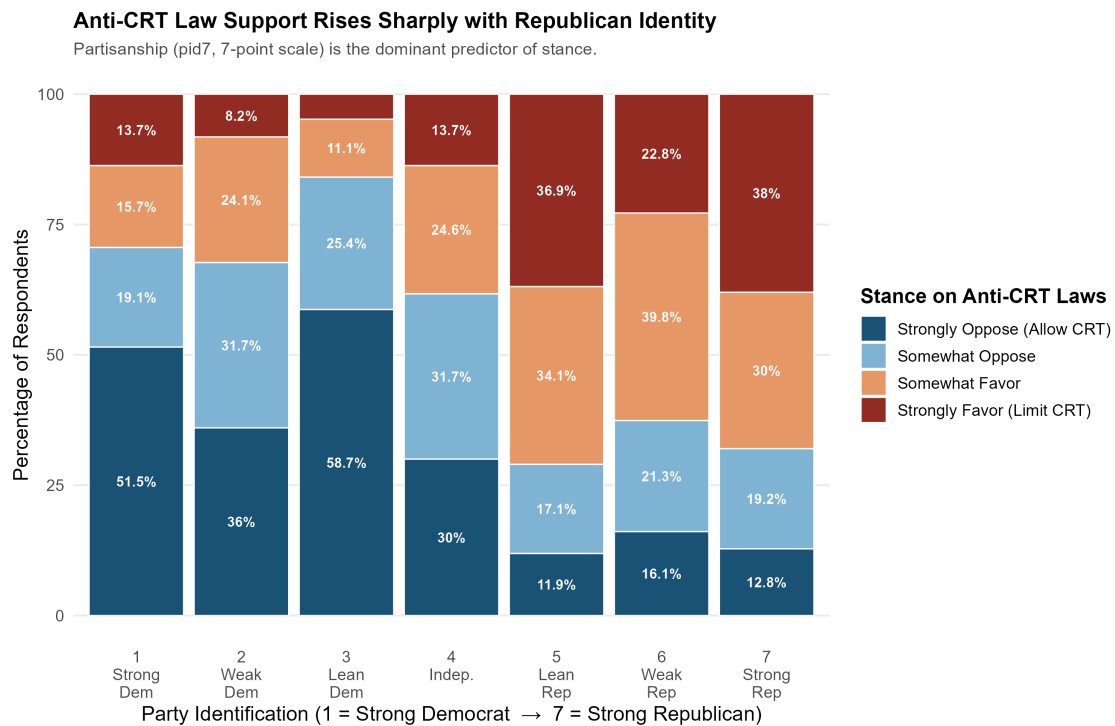


Figure 3: Distribution of stances on anti-CRT legislation across the 7-point party identification scale (1 = Strong Democrat, 7 = Strong Republican). Source: VAND0049.

5 BLM Support (RPS Wave 1)

65.6% of RPS respondents expressed some degree of support for the BLM movement. Political party identification was the single largest dividing line: Democrats and Independents were significantly more supportive than Republicans on every point on the scale. Respondents who could accurately describe BLM's stated goals were also more likely to support it independently of party, suggesting a portion of opposition reflects unfamiliarity with the movement's platform rather than genuine ideological disagreement. A regression was tested on seven specific types of family conversations about race and policing (**Figure 4**). The clearest positive predictor was when parents taught their kids about White privilege, which carried a coefficient of $+0.153$ ($p < 0.001$). Teaching that people are equal regardless of race ($+0.092$, $p < 0.01$) and that important historical figures exist across many groups ($+0.073$, $p < 0.05$) also showed significant positive associations. What these three things all have in common is that they frame racial dynamics as something socially embedded rather than individual behavior. On the opposite end, respondents who taught their kids that Black people should simply be more respectful toward police showed a coefficient of -0.158 ($p < 0.001$), the strongest of the seven parent items. This is an example of respectability politics which boils down to the idea that a marginalized group can assimilate and prevent discrimination by appealing to the majority via adopting acceptable behavior, manners, and values. Parents who pass on

such messages are themselves significantly less supportive of a movement that inherently rejects respectability politics; because the survey measures the parents' own views, it cannot show how their children turn out.

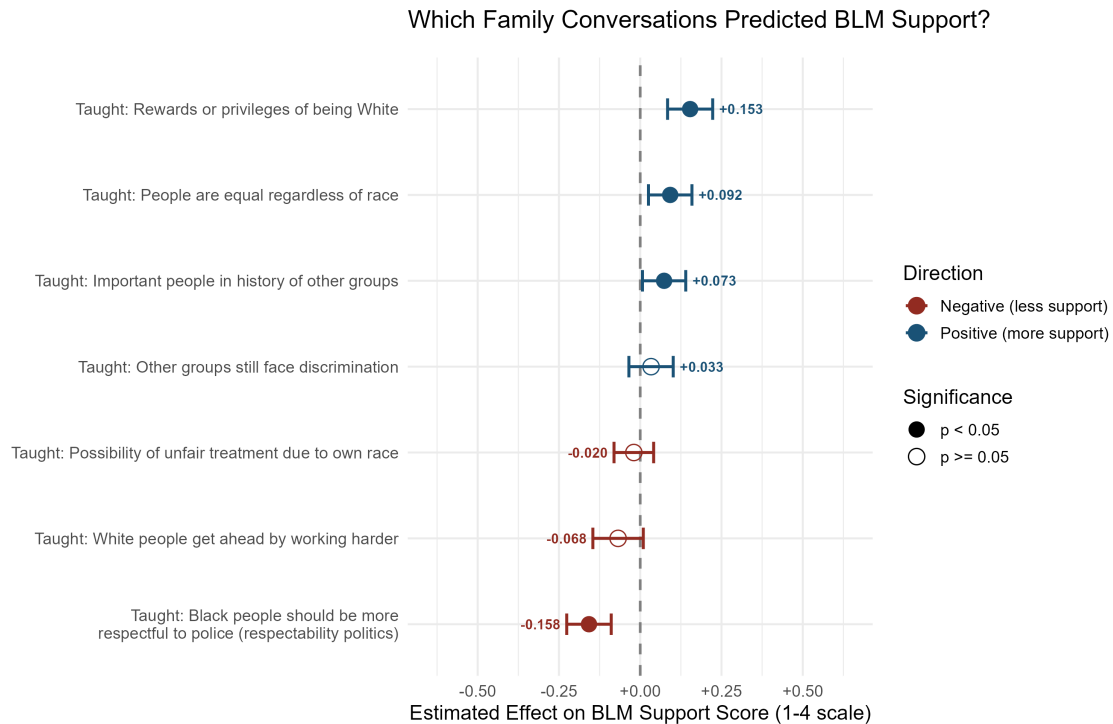


Figure 4: OLS regression coefficients (with 95% confidence intervals) for seven parental socialization variables predicting BLM support (Q26, 1–4 scale). Source: RPS Wave 1.

6 Conclusion

American views on race in the classroom are often not about the policies themselves. Public opinion shifts based on how topics are framed and the values people have instilled. Party identification is a recurring theme across all three datasets, and it becomes the dominant factor once CRT legislation enters the picture. The way parents teach their kids about race also reflects their outlook on movements like BLM, despite a potential knowledge gap on the subject matter. Schools will continue to be heavily contested by parents and legislators as places to cultivate children to their particular liking.